

Chapter 34 - Part 7

"So you're using this as evidence to suspect she's been acting all this time? Then what's her purpose?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

"Maybe she got tired of being a bad kid and wanted to become a good kid, or it could be histrionic personality disorder acting up," Zhao Xuning said. "I don't really care about it, since it's not really a big deal."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

Had it escalated to histrionic personality disorder already?

This touched on Xu Qingzhu's knowledge blind spot. She asked: "Is histrionic personality disorder a type of multiple personality disorder?"

"No," Zhao Xuning said. "Histrionic personality disorder belongs to psychiatric illnesses. You can ask Dr. Gu about it—she knows more in this area."

After saying this, she paused: "But I still suggest you don't be too curious. Your attention should be more focused on the company now."

Xu Qingzhu sighed and smiled helplessly: "I understand. Thank you for the reminder."

If not for Zhao Xuning's reminder, she wouldn't have realized at all that her recent behavior had the risk of crossing boundaries.

As Zhao Xuning said, paying too much attention to someone would definitely generate different emotions.

And the current Liang Shi was too dangerous.

One careless step could make someone lose control.

Xu Qingzhu collected her thoughts and asked instead: "Have you contacted Weiwei recently?"

"No," Zhao Xuning said. "She's already blocked my number and deleted me on WeChat, so... I guess we've broken off our friendship."

"She hasn't contacted me either," Xu Qingzhu said. "I called her that night, but she didn't answer."

"Give her time to think it through properly," Zhao Xuning said calmly. "I've explained everything I should have explained. Between us and Chen Liuying, she believes Chen Liuying's words more, so there's nothing more for us to say."

"Do you know anything about Chen Liuying?" Xu Qingzhu said. "I've looked her up. The internet is full of negative stories about her now. If Weiwei goes back to work recently, she should be very busy. I actually want to contact her, but... she's giving me the cold shoulder. And Weiwei wasn't like this before. Did she change after dating Chen Liuying?"

"Do you contact each other often? Your contact frequency with her is about every fifteen days, and you were only close during school. Society is different from school. After starting work, especially after you got married, your contact frequency would change. Everyone's work environment also reshapes their personality secondarily, so the gap between you two now is the result of gradual accumulation. It has some relationship with Chen Liuying, but it's not entirely related to her." Zhao Xuning analyzed very rationally, her tone casual, as if talking about strangers.

"You're so calm," Xu Qingzhu couldn't help saying. "Do you really have no feelings for Weiwei anymore?"

"We were friends once, but ultimately at some point we had to part ways," Zhao Xuning remained calm and composed. "I've already sorted out my emotions, so I won't be too affected."

Xu Qingzhu pressed her lips together: "Alright, but Chen Liuying's behavior that day made me very uncomfortable."

"It's a form of emotional PUA¹ tactic," Zhao Xuning said. "She uses Bai Weiwei's love for her to implement psychological control. After that incident happened, she constantly instilled in Bai Weiwei the idea that Bai Weiwei had been seen by others, that her body was dirty, even disgusting, that no one in this world would love her anymore except Chen Liuying.

So Bai Weiwei would develop fear from her heart and become even more unable to leave her. You said that day it was because you suggested breaking up that Bai Weiwei spoke harshly to you. I looked into it later—by that time, Bai Weiwei already believed she couldn't possibly leave Chen Liuying. So when you made that suggestion, her psychological defense mechanism would treat you as an enemy, searching her memory for all your bad points to break ties with you."

After Zhao Xuning finished speaking, she sighed: "Everyone has their own fate."

Xu Qingzhu was already shocked by this long explanation: "Psychological control? Chen Liuying is really despicable."

"People who implement PUA tactics don't necessarily realize they're doing PUA, and those being PUA'd don't realize it either. This is just human nature's dark side. Chen Liuying just pushed this dark side to the extreme," Zhao Xuning said. "I sent messages to Bai Weiwei, analyzed it for her, and made sure she saw them, but she still didn't reply to either of us. So I'm more inclined to think she doesn't want us to interfere in this matter."

"Are we really just going to ignore it?" Xu Qingzhu was surprised. "Weiwei is our friend."

"She doesn't consider me a friend," Zhao Xuning chuckled lightly. "I've always maintained distance with her."

When she discovered that no matter what, she couldn't forget that person hidden deep in her heart, she had already made things clear with Bai Weiwei.

At that time, they were just playing games together often, occasionally chatting until late at night when they were bored. Bai Weiwei would complain to her about difficulties encountered at work, and she would serve as a trash can.

She had approached the relationship with Bai Weiwei with the intention of entering a romantic relationship. After all, they got along well in games, and Bai Weiwei had an outgoing and cheerful personality, clear in her loves and hates, completely different from her previous girlfriend who had a stuffy personality, which could complement her own personality flaws.

But one day when she got drunk at a bar, the bartender asked her to have someone pick her up, and she instinctively called Shen Hui².

That's when she knew she hadn't sorted out her previous relationship yet, so she rather calmly extinguished those ambiguous sparks between them.

After that, they would only meet when Bai Weiwei was hospitalized or when Xu Qingzhu was hospitalized.

They didn't contact each other at other times.

The relationship between them wasn't as good as others thought.

Xu Qingzhu was also shocked by this news and said helplessly: "How many things between you two don't I know about?"

"Probably many?" Zhao Xuning didn't hide anything either. "Mainly because you got married and we don't contact each other often, so you don't know."

"Since I got married, every time Weiwei and I met, she would talk to me about divorce," Xu Qingzhu said wearily, recalling every meeting with Bai Weiwei where she had to deal with and deflect, and later they rarely met. "I didn't completely open up to her about our family matters, so I could only keep deflecting, hoping she wouldn't bring up this topic anymore. I think our friendship broke down starting from my lack of trust."

Xu Qingzhu began to reflect.

She cherished Bai Weiwei as a friend very much. Many beautiful memories from university were created together with Bai Weiwei.

In this friendship, she indeed wasn't sincere enough.

But couldn't all friendships that emerged from the ivory tower last long?

She had heard of good roommates who rented together after graduation but fell out after a short time.

She had also heard of good sisters who went to work at the same company but later fell out over trivial matters.

At that time, Bai Weiwei said they would definitely be an exception because their ideals were different, and they wouldn't live together after graduation. Their friendship would definitely last long like it had been preserved.

But in just a few years, it had already become like this.

The breakdown of a relationship must involve problems on both sides.

But Zhao Xuning said: "Why would it start from you? If friends or best friends must share everything in detail, that would be lacking too much personal space. Everyone needs privacy, and Bai Weiwei was constantly invading your privacy space. You two were destined not to remain good friends forever."

Xu Qingzhu: "..."

For a moment, Xu Qingzhu felt Zhao Xuning made sense.

But—

"Dr. Zhao, do you have friends?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning suddenly fell silent. She raised an eyebrow: "Do you count? Or... Liang Shi barely counts too?"

Xu Qingzhu was shocked, her jaw nearly dropping: "When did Liang Shi become your friend?"

"I find her quite interesting," Zhao Xuning said. "Worth studying."

—Research subjects also count as friends?

No.

—Are you this emotionally cold even to research subjects?

Xu Qingzhu felt she had never understood Zhao Xuning.

She couldn't help being curious again: "Dr. Zhao, have you ever in your life had moments when you couldn't maintain your composure?"

Zhao Xuning paused slightly and reminded her very rigorously: "My life isn't over yet."

"Then in your limited first half of life," Xu Qingzhu said.

Zhao Xuning fell silent.

She exhaled lightly and said in a nostalgic and tender tone: "Yes."

Once in a room filled with roses, on a bed scattered with starlight, in moments when breathing was constantly amplified, when that person untied her robe, revealing the exquisite body underneath that was so revealing the fabric was almost negligible.

She had been pulled down from her pedestal countless times by that person.

Her calmness and coldness had always vanished completely in front of her.

If Zhao Xuning was a well-trained army, then Shen Hui's appearance could make her fall into complete disarray.

Footnotes:

¹ PUA: Pickup Artist, but in this context refers to psychological manipulation tactics used to control someone emotionally

² Shen Hui: Zhao Xuning's ex-girlfriend who she still has feelings for